

Synthesis and Physical Design on CAE

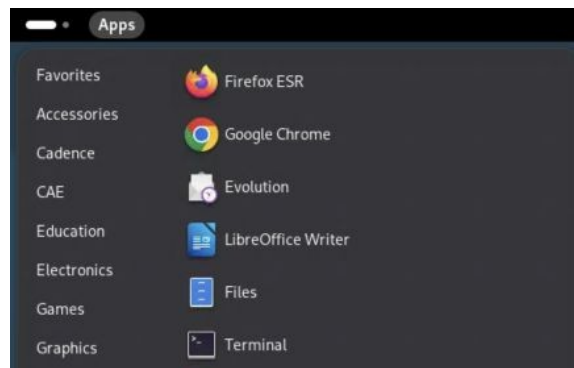
By Abhinav Nandwani

Use this guide to run synthesis, inspect mapped logic and timing in Design Vision, and bring a small design into IC Compiler II for physical inspection. Keep the terminal transcript, scripts, and GUI observations together. The register example teaches the workflow; its area and timing are not accelerator estimates.

Sign in to Guacamole

Guacamole displays a CAE Linux desktop in your browser. The tools run on the CAE machine. Use your own UW NetID and confirm that your account can reach CAE Linux services before the lab.

1. On your laptop, open <https://guacamole.cae.wisc.edu> in a browser.
2. Complete the UW web sign-in with your NetID and password, then complete MFA if requested.
3. At the Linux login screen, enter your UW NetID and password again. Use your NetID credentials at this second prompt too. The old separate CAE username and password are not the instructions for this service.
4. Wait for the Linux desktop. Open Apps in the upper-left corner and choose Terminal under Favorites. Maximize the terminal by double-clicking its title bar.
5. Keep the Guacamole tab open. A terminal inside this desktop is already on CAE; do not SSH back into CAE from it.



Open Terminal from the CAE Apps menu.

If you already have an active session, the browser may reconnect without showing every login screen. If sign-in fails, record which prompt failed: UW web sign-in, MFA, or the Linux desktop login. These are different stages.

Official CAE login instructions and screenshots: <https://kb.wisc.edu/cae/163323>

Enter the Synopsys environment

Run these commands in the CAE terminal, one line at a time. Do not type a prompt such as \$ or synopsys> before a command.

```
module load synopsys/suite
synopsys-run
command -v vcs dc_shell verdi icc2_shell pt_shell
```

The prompt becomes synopsys>. The module selects the site setup; the container provides the operating environment expected by the tools. Load the module before entering the container and repeat this setup for every new terminal used for Synopsys tools.

```
synopsys> command -v vcs dc_shell verdi icc2_shell pt_shell
/srv/auto/apps/synopsys-2026/vcs/Y-2026.03/bin/vcs
/srv/auto/apps/synopsys-2026/syn/Y-2026.03/bin/dc_shell
/srv/auto/apps/synopsys-2026/verdi/Y-2026.03/bin/verdi
/srv/auto/apps/synopsys-2026/icc2/X-2025.06-SP3/bin/icc2_shell
/srv/auto/apps/synopsys-2026/prime/Y-2026.03/bin/pt_shell
synopsys>
```

Tool paths inside the working CAE Synopsys container.

Companion code

Synthesis runner: https://github.com/abhinavnandwani/cae-synopsys-guides/blob/main/lab/run_lab.py

Synthesis script: <https://github.com/abhinavnandwani/cae-synopsys-guides/blob/main/lab/synth/run.tcl>

Reference library script: https://github.com/abhinavnandwani/cae-synopsys-guides/blob/main/lab/physical/build_reference.tcl

Floorplan script: <https://github.com/abhinavnandwani/cae-synopsys-guides/blob/main/lab/physical/floorplan.tcl>

Commands below use ~/cae-synopsys-guides/lab as the exercise directory. The recorded screenshots show the original dated demonstration folder.

Work confidently in the terminal

The current directory affects relative paths. `pwd` prints it, `ls` lists files, `cd ..` moves to the parent, and `cd ~/cae-synopsys-guides/lab` returns to the exercise. A leading `/` means an absolute path; `~` means your home directory. Quote paths containing spaces.

Prompt or location	Commands that belong there
Laptop Terminal or PowerShell	<code>ssh</code> to reach the CAE host shell.
CAE host shell	<code>module load synopsys/suite</code> , then <code>synopsys-run</code> .
Container <code>synopsys></code>	Linux commands, <code>python3 run_lab.py</code> , <code>vcs</code> , <code>verdi</code> , <code>dc_shell</code> , and <code>icc2_shell</code> .
Tool prompt such as <code>dc_shell></code>	Tool Tcl commands such as <code>read_ddc</code> , <code>report_timing</code> , and <code>help</code> .

Use these from the exercise folder to inspect source and logs without changing them:

```
ls -lh
cat rtl/sb_flop.v
sed -n '1,80p' tb/tb.sv
less runs/YOUR_RUN/compile.log
grep -nE 'Error|Fatal|Warning' runs/YOUR_RUN/compile.log
tail -n 30 runs/YOUR_RUN/simulate.log
```

Replace `YOUR_RUN` with an actual directory printed by the runner. In `less`, use Space to advance, `/Error` then Enter to search, `n` for the next match, and `q` to return to the shell. An Up-arrow recalls a command; Tab completes a path. Read a command before rerunning it.

For an interactive foreground command that is stuck, `Ctrl+C` requests interruption. For a GUI launched with `&`, close the application through its File menu. `jobs` lists jobs started by that shell. Keep logs: `command > run.log 2>&1` sends both standard output and errors to a file. Immediately after a command, `echo $?` reports its exit status, but a zero status alone does not prove the design passed.

Connect without the browser when useful

For terminal-only work, open a terminal on your laptop and run `ssh YOUR_NETID@best-tux.cae.wisc.edu`, then load the module and enter the container as above. Use Guacamole for the GUI steps in this handout. SSH and Guacamole may reach different hosts, but your CAE home directory is shared.

When finished, save work, close the EDA applications, and run `exit` to leave the container. Log out of the Linux desktop from the upper-right system menu. Closing the browser alone can leave the session running during CAE's two-hour reconnection window.

Run synthesis and inspect the outputs

From the exercise folder inside the Synopsys container:

```
python3 run_lab.py synthesis
```

The runner creates a fresh directory, selects the installed teaching library, calls `dc_shell -f synth/run.tcl`, and checks diagnostics, the completion marker, and required files. Change into the exact directory printed as `RUN_DIRECTORY`.

```
less synthesis.log
cat area.rpt
cat timing.rpt
cat constraints.rpt
cat constraints.sdc
cat mapped.v
```

Output	What it tells you
synthesis.log	Tool version, source loading, linking, compilation, and diagnostics.
mapped.v	Structural netlist using cells in the selected library.
mapped.ddc	Design Compiler database for resuming inspection in Design Vision.
constraints.sdc	Exported timing intent, including clocks and I/O delays.
area.rpt	Cell count and mapped cell area, plus any estimated interconnect area.
timing.rpt	Reported path, arrival time, required time, and slack.
constraints.rpt	Constraint violations reported by this run.

The tested one-register run has two mapped cells and cell area 7.116032 in the library's area units. Its default maximum-delay report has slack 8.86 ns. The report's total area includes an interconnect estimate; it is not a routed core area. Do not compare these numbers with another run without checking library, corner, constraints, and implementation stage.

Read the synthesis script

From the exercise root, open `synth/run.tcl`. The runner supplies `SB_RTL` and `SB_TARGET_LIBRARY` as absolute paths. `target_library` controls available mapping cells; `link_library` controls reference resolution. The script reads RTL, selects `sb_flop`, links, creates a clock and I/O delays, compiles, checks the design, and exports the results.

Make timing assumptions explicit

The teaching constraints are deliberately simple:

```
create_clock -name clk -period 10 [get_ports clk]
set_input_delay 1 -clock clk [get_ports {rst d}]
set_output_delay 1 -clock clk [get_ports q]
```

The period is 10 ns. The input delay reserves time for the external launch side; the output delay reserves time for the external capture side. These values are assumptions for learning the tools, not a project timing budget. Real constraints must also address applicable generated clocks, input transition, output load, uncertainty, exceptions, and operating scenarios.

Use these Tcl commands in `dc_shell` or Design Vision after loading the design:

```
check_design
check_timing
report_clock
report_timing -delay_type max -max_paths 5
report_timing -delay_type min -max_paths 5
report_constraint -all_violators
report_area
```

`check_design` asks structural questions; `check_timing` helps reveal missing or inconsistent timing setup. Maximum-delay and minimum-delay checks answer different questions. For a setup path, slack is required time minus arrival time; for a hold path the relationship is different. Always identify the analysis type before interpreting the sign and number.

Read one path completely

Start with the startpoint and endpoint, then identify the clock and path group. Follow the cell and net contributions to data arrival time. Read the required time and slack. In the recorded example, the path starts at `rst`, ends at the mapped register, and reports arrival 1.01 ns, required 9.88 ns, and slack 8.86 ns after rounding.

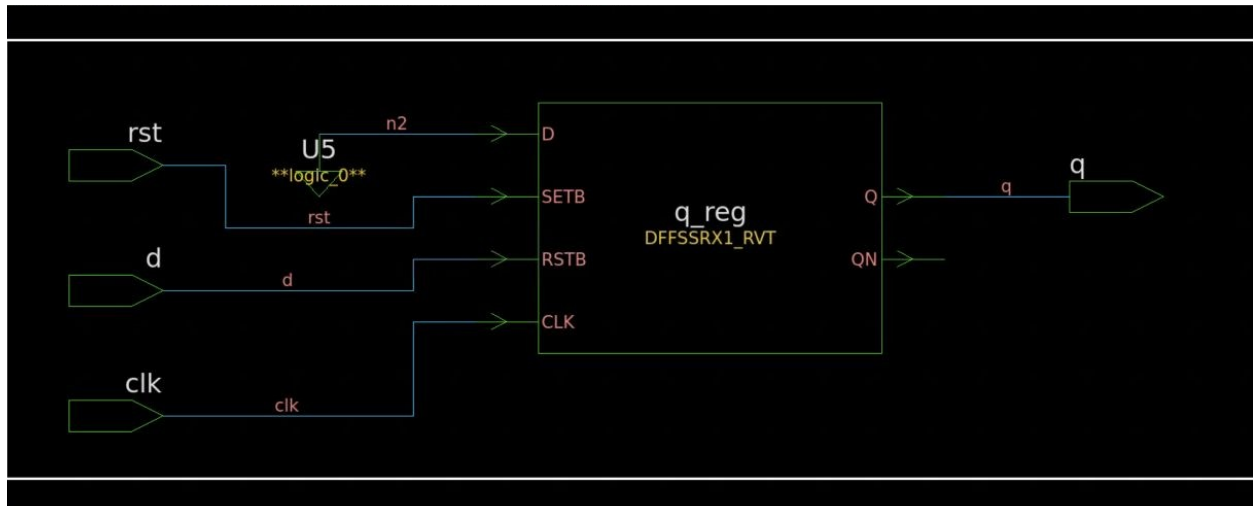
Positive slack for this path does not show that every intended path exists or is constrained. Pre-layout timing also lacks the final physical parasitics and clock tree. Keep a stage label on every report: mapped synthesis, placed, post-clock-tree, or routed.

Load the mapped design in Design Vision

In Guacamole, launch `design_vision` from the synthesis run directory. Maximize the window and wait for startup to complete. At the bottom Tcl input line, enter:

```
set edk /srv/auto/apps/saed32_edk/2023/lib/stdcell_rvt
set dbdir "$edk/SAED32_EDK/lib/stdcell_rvt/db_nldm"
set lib "$dbdir/saed32rvt_tt1p05v25c.db"
set_app_var target_library [list $lib]
set_app_var link_library [concat * $target_library]
read_ddc mapped.ddc
current_design sb_flop
link
read_sdc constraints.sdc
check_design
```

1. Read the console after each command. Resolve missing library or unresolved-reference errors before drawing conclusions.
2. Select `sb_flop` in Logical Hierarchy, then choose Schematic, New Schematic View.
3. Double-click the module boundary box to expand the mapped contents.
4. Choose View, Zoom, Zoom Fit All. Collapse an unused pane to give the schematic more width; double-click its bottom tab to restore it.

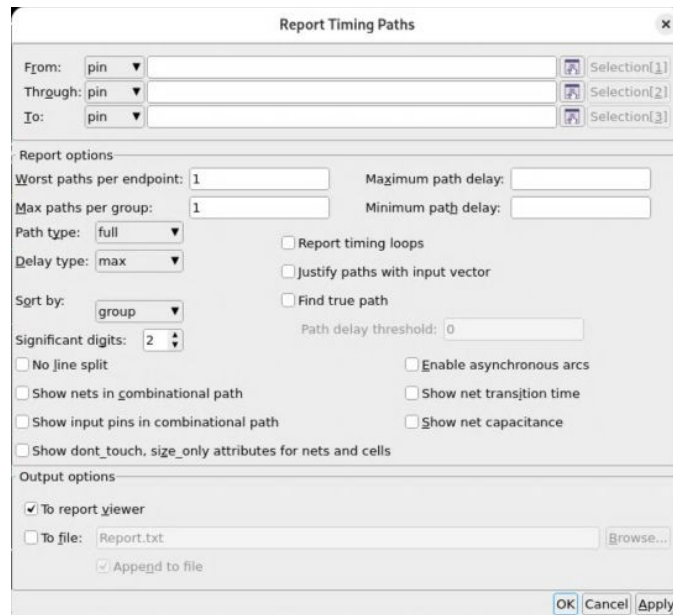


Design Vision showing the expanded mapped register and its ports.

Trace the boundary ports to the mapped cells. Inspect `q_reg` and compare its pin connections with `mapped.v`. Synthesis can use library-specific transformations, so the cell's actual function matters. A schematic confirms connectivity and mapping choices; it does not replace formal equivalence or functional verification.

Generate and investigate timing in the GUI

Choose Timing, Report Timing Path. Start with max delay, full path type, one worst path per endpoint, and one path per group. Leave From, Through, and To empty for the initial report, and enable To report viewer.



The timing dialog used to select the initial report.

1. Click OK and allow the report pane to populate. Confirm the design, startpoint, endpoint, path group, and delay type.
2. Read the complete path through arrival time, required time, and slack. Scroll the report if necessary; the first screen may not contain the final slack line.
3. Use linked object names in the report and the schematic to locate the cell or net under investigation.
4. Return to the timing dialog to narrow From or To when investigating a specific interface or register. Repeat with minimum delay when investigating hold behavior.
5. Read the generated Tcl command in the console. Preserve the equivalent command in the run script so the report can be regenerated outside the GUI.

For larger text, use View, Preferences, Style Settings. Normal controls interface labels and Monospace controls report text. Enlarge the pane as well as the font. Save reports from Tcl with `redirect -file focused_timing.rpt {report_timing -max_paths 5}`.

Understand the inputs to physical implementation

ICC2 needs physical technology and cell abstracts in addition to logical timing models. A successful `dc_shell` run using a `.db` does not establish that the physical setup is complete.

Input	Purpose
Technology file or technology library	Layers, routing geometry, sites, and physical rules used by implementation.
Reference cell library	Physical cell abstracts, pins, and logical/timing views, normally packaged as NDM for ICC2.
Mapped netlist	Instances and connectivity to implement.
SDC and scenario setup	Clocks, interface budgets, exceptions, and analysis conditions.
RC technology	Parasitic modeling appropriate to the implementation and extraction flow.
Floorplan and power intent	Die/core geometry, macros, pins, power nets, and applicable domain requirements.

The accessible CAE SAED32 EDK contains the timing `.db`, standard-cell LEF, and a Milkyway technology file used by this teaching exercise. The separate SAED32 PDK directory returned permission denied for the tested account. These are different paths. Keep licensed library data on CAE; the companion package contains scripts referencing installed data, not copies of that data.

The teaching corner is RVT, TT, 1.05 V, 25 C. It is not a project process or signoff-corner decision. Agree the project library, corners, RC setup, and constraints before reporting meaningful PPA.

Prepare the teaching reference library from the terminal

Finish the synthesis exercise first. In a container shell, set the successful run directory and create a separate physical run:

```
SB_LAB="$HOME/cae-synopsys-guides/lab"
export SB_SYNTH_RUN="$SB_LAB/runs/YOUR_SYNTHESIS_RUN"
SB_PHYS=$(mktemp -d "$SB_LAB/runs/physical-XXXXXX")
cd "$SB_PHYS"
icc2_lm_shell -f "$SB_LAB/physical/build_reference.tcl" \
  > library.log 2>&1
less library.log
```

Replace YOUR_SYNTHESIS_RUN with the actual directory. The script runs in Library Manager, whose prompt is lm_shell>. It creates a workspace using the installed technology file, reads the timing .db and cell LEF, checks the workspace, and writes sb_rvt.ndm in this private run directory.

```
set edk /srv/auto/apps/saed32_edk/2023
set cells $edk/lib/stdcell_rvt/SAED32_EDK/lib/stdcell_rvt
create_workspace -technology $edk/tech/milkyway/saed32nm_1p9m_mw.tf \
  -flow normal sb_rvt
read_db $cells/db_nldm/saed32rvt_tt1p05v25c.db
read_lef $cells/lef/saed32nm_rvt_1p9m.lef
check_workspace
commit_workspace -output sb_rvt.ndm
```

The tested workspace check succeeded and created 294 frames. Its diagnostics included a technology-layer warning, a LEF bus-character warning, and warnings about large M1 routing blockages in cell abstracts. Preserve and review them. Successful import does not certify the library for routing or signoff.

Keep library.log with the run. Stop if the workspace check fails or the NDM output is missing. Do not copy the generated reference library into a public repository or the handout package.

Import and floorplan the register in ICC2

In the same physical run directory, run:

```
icc2_shell -f "$SB_LAB/physical/floorplan.tcl" \
  > floorplan.log 2>&1
less floorplan.log
grep -nE 'Error|Warning|REGISTER_|FLOORPLAN_DONE' floorplan.log
```

The script creates sb_flop.dlib, imports the mapped netlist, links the design against the reference NDM, reads the SDC, initializes a small die and core, makes an initial floorplan placement, and saves the block and library. The corresponding interactive Tcl commands are:

```
create_lib -ref_libs {sb_rvt.ndm} sb_flop.dlib
read_verilog -top sb_flop $env(SB_SYNTH_RUN)/mapped.v
link_block
read_sdc $env(SB_SYNTH_RUN)/constraints.sdc
initialize_floorplan -control_type die \
  -boundary {{0 0} {20 20}} -core_offset 2
create_placement -floorplan
get_attribute [get_cells q_reg] origin
get_attribute [get_cells q_reg] physical_status
save_block
save_lib
```

The boundary and offset are teaching dimensions in the technology's distance units. The tool snaps the core to the site rows. This tiny design deliberately leaves plenty of empty space. It does not establish the accelerator's utilization target or floorplan dimensions.

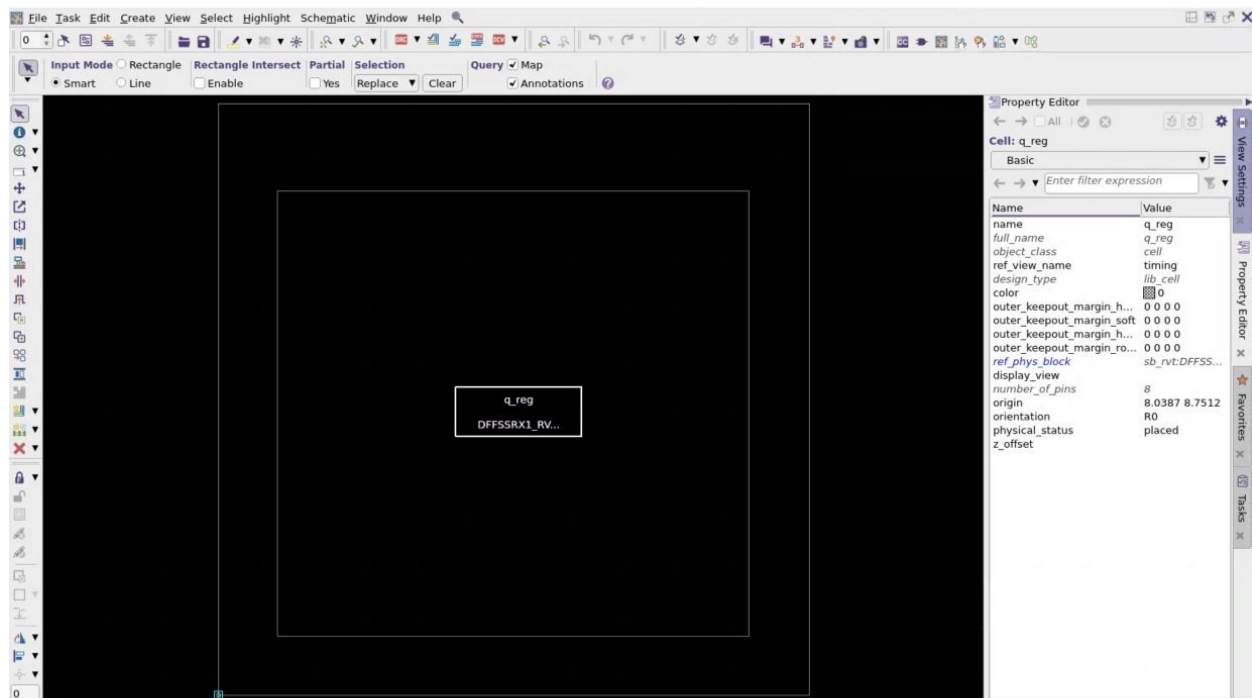
Check the successful-link message, floorplan-completion message, cell location/status, and saved files. The tested technology also prompted ICC2 to derive missing preferred routing directions. Review that setup before routing a project design. The completion marker only means the script reached its end; errors earlier in the log still need attention.

Open and inspect the physical design in the GUI

Start `icc2_shell` in the physical run directory. At its Tcl prompt, reopen the saved design:

```
open_lib sb_flop.dlib
open_block sb_flop
start_gui
```

If the block is already open in the same session, use only `start_gui`. Maximize the IC Compiler II window. Its title should identify `sb_flop.dlib:sb_flop.design`. Check that title before inspecting or editing anything.



The initial physical view of the register in its teaching floorplan.

1. Identify the outer die boundary and the inner core boundary. The core is inset from the die and aligned to the placement sites.
2. Find the rectangle labelled `q_reg`. Click it once to select the cell, then open the Property Editor tab on the right.
3. Read its name, reference view, origin, orientation, and `physical_status`. The recorded initial placement reports `placed`; this is not a statement that detailed legalization or routing checks passed.
4. Compare the selected instance with `mapped.v`. The logical netlist, physical abstract, and timing view must refer to compatible cells and pins.
5. With the cell selected, choose View, Zoom, Zoom Fit Selection. Choose Zoom Fit All to recover the overview. The right-side View Settings panel controls visible objects and layers. Hiding an object does not remove it from the design.

The empty space and absence of a routed interconnect network are expected at this stage. An initial floorplan placement is useful for learning selection, geometry, and database inspection. It is not a finished physical design.

Connect GUI observations to repeatable commands

The Property Editor provides concrete database attributes. Use the tool console to query the same selected design objects explicitly:

```
get_attribute [get_cells q_reg] origin
get_attribute [get_cells q_reg] orientation
get_attribute [get_cells q_reg] physical_status
get_object_name [get_pins q_reg/*]
```

The recorded cell origin was approximately {8.0387 8.7512}, orientation R0, and physical status placed. Coordinates can change when the floorplan or placement settings change; compare the geometry and status with the run you actually opened.

When a larger design is difficult to navigate, select an object by its name or query it in the console before zooming and tracing its connections. Confirm both the instance name and reference cell. A similarly named cell in another hierarchy is a different object.

Inspect messages as part of GUI use. Open the Console tab at the bottom and use View, Error Browser for diagnostics. Start from the first relevant setup error. Check the saved run log when the GUI only shows the most recent messages.

Save a checkpoint and know what remains

After an intentional change, save the block and library using `save_block` and `save_lib`. Keep the script and log that produced that state. Reopening the saved block is a useful check that the result is reproducible beyond the current GUI session.

The demonstrated physical exercise ends after import, floorplan initialization, and initial placement. It has not built a power grid, assigned a final pin plan, performed detailed legalization, constructed the clock tree, routed signals, extracted final parasitics, or passed signoff checks. Before extending it, establish the approved technology, RC data, scenarios, power setup, and physical checks for the project.

Do not hide a warning by suppressing it just to get a cleaner screenshot. Record whether it is a teaching-library limitation, a missing flow input, or a real design problem. Separate those from the measured outcomes of a completed implementation stage.

Build chip-level and per-unit runs

Keep one explicit configuration for the chip and one for each unit. Each configuration should identify its top module, ordered source manifest, parameters, clocks, interface budgets, library/corner, and implementation status. A stub may make the flow runnable while RTL is unfinished, but its outputs and timing assumptions must be visible in the run record.

Evidence to retain for each target	Review question
Input manifest and revision	Exactly what design and stubs were implemented?
Library and constraints	Under what assumptions are the numbers meaningful?
Logs and design checks	Did the tool resolve references and complete each stage?
Mapped netlist and SDC	Can the next stage consume the result reproducibly?
Saved physical block and stage	Is this imported, floorplanned, placed, clocked, or routed?
Area, timing, congestion, and violations	What passes, what fails, and what remains unmeasured?

The immediate project work is a runnable chip-level flow plus separate unit runs with clearly marked stubs where necessary. Keep the flow reproducible as real blocks arrive. Do not present stub area as an estimate of the missing block or an empty timing report as closure.

Troubleshoot by stage

For synthesis, start with source loading, top selection, linking, and constraints. For physical import, start with technology and reference libraries, cell/pin resolution, and netlist consistency. For placement, inspect sites, floorplan geometry, legal cell locations, and power connectivity before tuning optimization options.

If a license check fails, save the exact tool diagnostic and version. If a GUI appears unresponsive during launch, allow startup to complete before starting another copy. If a command is unfamiliar, use `help -verbose command_name` or `man command_name` in the tool version you are running.

Close GUI tools, save your checkpoints, leave the container, and log out of the CAE desktop when finished. Design Compiler and Design Vision were exercised on Y-2026.03; ICC2 uses X-2025.06-SP3 on this CAE installation.

Setup: <https://kb.wisc.edu/cae-software-guide>

ICC2 capabilities: <https://www.synopsys.com/implementation-and-signoff/physical-implementation/ic-compiler.html>